

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 278

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1950-1961

Coverage Date: 1950-1961

Place Coverage: Nyae Nyae Region, Namibia And Botswana

Section Title(S): ARRANGEMENTS FOR MARRIAGE

Our endeavor to bring to light the meaning of the ritual elements yielded little. The meaning or origin of the design on the face, I am convinced, was not withheld but was instead lost to memory, lore, or myth. "It is our custom" was all the people could tell me.

302
[Personal Grooming](#)

585
[Nuptials](#)

The carrying of the bride to the marriage shelter suggested to me the ritual of the feet not touching the ground, a ritual frequently observed, according to Frazer, by menstruating girls. The !Kung, however, had no such interpretation of it. They think that carrying the girl is meant to suggest that she is reluctant to go to the arms of her bridegroom. To be proper, she should feign modesty and shyness even if she is eager to go and should show her reluctance to be separated from her own family. When the attendants take hold of the bride and groom by the arms and pull them a little they also symbolize the overcoming of reluctance and modesty, and perhaps there is even a vestige of bride-capture in that gesture. But I was not convinced that there might not have been another meaning to the carrying, no longer known, that related the bride to the menstruating girl being carried to and from her shelter.

585
[Nuptials](#)

The !Kung say that the sun is death-giving. When the three months of life-giving rains are past, the sun dries up the water pools; it kills the fresh leaves and fruits, dries the roots and berries, and would scorch the people if they did not find shade. They pity the morning star, the *kuli / gaishay*, which crosses the sky all day ahead of the sun, because it has no branches to carry for shade and cannot turn aside to rest under a tree. The sun is a "death-thing," *!khi tshi*, and the bride is shielded from it. A wedding, they say, is a "night-thing," *du tshi*.

585
[Nuptials](#)
 821
[Ethnometeorology](#)

The most important element of behavior with respect to kinship in the wedding rite is the avoidance of the parents. Any kinswoman (preferably a young one) who is tall enough and strong enough, whether she herself is married or not, and whether or not she has the joking relationship with the bride, may carry the bride and any may attend her. Only the mother absolutely must not do so. The groom's father must not attend him. Neither pair of parents goes to sit by the wedding fire, for they must not sit near their son's wife or daughter's husband, nor speak to  279 them. Guests of mature years might go and sit by the wedding fire only if they have the joking relationship with both the bride and the groom. Very young guests, such as we saw at N!ai's and / Gunda's fire, may go, whether or not they joke with the bride and groom, because the avoidances are not stringently observed with young children.

585

Nuptials

602

Kin Relationships

784

Avoidance And Taboo

858

Status Of Children

Human Relations Area Files

*755 Prospect Street**New Haven, CT 06511*General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.eduIssues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)